NZ Rogaining Association national meeting (with collaborating reps from NZ Orienteering Federation) to consider the future of NZ Rogaining Champs

Compiled GG Hunter

Date, venue: Sunday 12 November 2012, 8.30am to noon, Christchurch
Present: Nick Collins (Taranaki), Mark Copeland (Rotorua), Mondo Kopua (Marlborough), Pete Squires, Bill Kennedy, Douglas Woods, Emma de Lacey, Dave Laurie, Grant Hunter, Tim Farrant (absent for first and last parts), (Christchurch); Michael Woods (Wellington) and Stuart Payne (rep. NZOF)

Agenda

- Delivering NZ Champs each year; and what are we doing for 2013?
- Australasian Champs as proposed by ARA
- NZ Rogaine series
- NZ rule change – lower age for juniors

Items for full NZRA committee to confirm or otherwise following this meeting

- A NZ champs rogaine event must be of 24 hour duration. If this cannot be achieved in a year for logistic or other reasons, there will be no championship that year.
- NZRA supports re-use of venues, no more frequently than four-yearly, for NZ champs events.
- NZRA supports the concept of an Australasian rogaine champs, as advocated by ARA, and commits on a best-endeavours basis to organising this event 5-yearly, first time expected in 2016.
- Secretary NZRA copies-in CEO NZOF to significant NZRA committee meeting minutes and other relevant documents.

1. Delivering the NZ Champs

Summary of agreements wrt NZ Champs - General

- *NZ champs will always be 24-hour, even if we must miss some years – 'best endeavours'
- Identify fixed venues (two in each island) for reuse to improve efficiency – rotate 4-yearly, plus also encourage new areas.
- Dave Laurie to collate all previous 24 hour event maps (with annotations) and coordinate a short list, and eventually an agreed 4+ venue set
- As much as possible, define roles to enable sharing the load, e.g., access/landowners/community links; course planning; event logistics etc
- NZRA to provide specialist resources, training etc as is possible.
- Compile written resources to aid rogaine planning - Grant to give Tim available event planning and organisational aids – access letters etc
- Get events into the national calendar as early as possible – say 1 year ahead?
- At this stage, continue to live with flexible seasonal staging (we have not yet found the ideal, and opportunities/ideals vary with region – but desirable to standardise)

**Note '24 hour or nothing' was not a universal view and no vote was taken at the meeting. At least one committee member not present at the meeting subsequently disagreed with this*

principle. There is always scope for this and other decision to be revisited by the full committee, and for wider dialogue with membership. (G Hunter, 15/1/13)

Summary agreements/actions for NZ Champs 2013

- Check NI 24 hour maps – past use (most likely), plus potential new areas
- Mark available to assess site options, select preferred area, arrange access
- Nick to try to pull together an organiser team – tapping into local/regional orienteering groups
- Letter from Secretary NZRA to NZOF to confirm discussion at this meeting and to 'formalise' engagement with orienteering clubs (e.g. make orienteers comfortable that NZOF endorses the collaboration).
- NZRA to offer technical support
- Set date asap (season is negotiable, but at least 6 months from 2012 (late November)
- Proceed in steps: e.g. need site (region) before engaging organising team.

Attendance numbers

Year	**Venue**	**Participants**	
		24 hour	**Short**
2012	Otago – Mahinerangi, 24th November	73	44
2011	Marlborough – Wither Hills, 19th March	92	24
2010	Akatarawas – Moonshine, 17th April	216 total across all events	
2009	Otago – Waikouati 7th March	96	44
2008	Taupo, 24th May	104	60
2007	Marlborough – Peggioh, 3rd March	127	No short event
2006	Wellington – Tararua, 18th February	204	No short event
2005	Otago – Middlemarch, 26th February	98	60
2004	Waikato – Waimarama, 6th March	76	40
2003	Otago – Roxburgh, 15th March	102	No short event

While numbers engaged in rogaining are growing nationally, interest in the 24 hour event is relatively static. For an individual, a 24 hour event eats up 4 days. In addition, serious competition will usually be curtailed the previous and following weekends. With so many other non-rogaine endurance events on offer, it's hard to fit one in. Younger people tend to prefer AR to 24 hour rogaines. More of a fun image. How to make rogaining more fun? More effort into promotion/posters/social media. People more fluid with their plans now - tend to commit closer to the event which can be unnerving for organisers.

Does NZ Champs event always need to be 24 hour?

A range of views on this.

- Meet the market. If people prefer short events, then listen
- If we don't have resources for 24 hr each year, then run with next best thing – 12 hour. Would require a NZ rule change (rule T1)

On the other hand:

- Must have 24hr events for champs – this is the core of the full rogaining endurance-based challenge. Must not water this down. Better to miss a year than go down the 'slippery slope' of watering down the champs standard.
- Need all-night experience. While you could replicate this in 12-hour overnighter, this would still not meet the standard for a national champs event.

- It is not just the overnight experience. A 24hr is much, much harder than 12hr mentally and physically.
- International standard is 24 hour. For NZ rogaines to meet this world standard, we must stay aligned. Qualification for entry in any limited entry WRC requires a 24hr championship.

While a number spoke in favour of 12 hour champs events in some years if a 24 hour event seemed impossible to stage, the predominant view was that the NZ champs must always be 24 hour. The date needs to be fixed well ahead (18 months or more), look towards a regular date, and some sort of branding for the Champs.

Organisational issues – how to make things more do-able

Building the resource base

- Rely on volunteers - can only achieve what you can achieve! Best endeavours.
- Build the local/regional capacity – work on juniors, get participants (all ages/stages) involved in organisation as well as participating.
- Commercial organising – possible, but have small participation base (entry fees) in 24 hr events. NZRA can subsidise/underwrite. Arguably, commercial organising may not build the base of organisers that are required to further rogaining in the longer term.

Written aids

- Agreed to collate and compile written aids to guide event organisers. e.g., planning, course setting, access negotiation, safety plans. Grant to assemble his materials for Tim who will start this process.

Allocating roles

- Setting aside national functions such as registration, promotion etc – also arguably map, navlight, present practice tends to be for a lead organiser in a region to take responsibility for all phases (access, planning, logistics event admin etc). This is demanding on an individual or core group.
- Can we split the roles more clearly to share the load?
- Suggested that the venue selection/access permission is an onerous, specialist role and there was strong support to separate this off. Landowner approach and liaison requires a particular personality type.
- Agreed this is a worthwhile approach but note that the venue organiser really needs to be local, to build local rapport, and to ensure excellent communication between planners and landowners/community. This model might not work for organisers who like the ‘longitudinal’ (landowner to participant) approach.

Repeat use of venue

- We strive for a new venue each year for the navigational challenge. This is very demanding in every respect as no organisational routine is possible.
- Full agreement that it seems reasonable to use a venue each say four years. Agreed we could establish up to two venues in each island and rotate between them, plus adding new venues as opportunities arise.

***Action*:** Dave to receive and collate maps (provided by previous organisers) of each 24 hour venue used previously (listed in the table above, plus 2 x WRC), with any notes to guide decisions about future use. Reconvene to consider the short list.

2. Australasian champs

- Seen as a first step towards a genuine 'regional champs' in terms of IRF definition.
- Agree we support this event –put to full NZRA committee for formal agreement.
- Would be NZ's turn to host this event in 2016.
- Tim Farrant agreed to take responsibility for organising 2016.

3. National rogaining series

- Aim to create a level below 24 hour champs, duration 6 to 12 hour.
- Deliver NI / SI 'regional' series in the short term, while seeking truly national longer term.
- Seeking three events in each island (upper/central (Rotorua Great Forest) /lower NI; Marlborough/Canterbury (H of W)/Otago SI (Invite Highland events). Get these events secured in the annual calendar
- Start simple.
- No intention at this stage to standardise grades – adopt whatever the events are using, but work towards standards.
- NZRA to offer organisers technical support, equipment etc
- Range of options for check points and scoring. Navlight is optional. But NO CRYPTIC CLUES.
- Apply good practice guidelines, not rules.
- Organise around a calendar year, preferably starting in 2013, with 4 or 6 events.
- NZOF expects to support this series in principle. NZRA to write to NZOF to invite their engagement and to alert orienteering clubs.

4. Lower limit for junior participation

- **Currently** under 18 requires parental/guardian written permission and signature on the indemnity form for all NZRA events.
- Suggested that the age limits set for 2012 Moonlight on Mahinerangi might be adopted for future events, ie. for a 24hr event any team with a person 16 or under must also have a person 21 or over. For a 12hr event or less any team with a person under 14 must also have a person 18 or over as currently in the NZ rules. (This needs to be tidied – what about events between 12 and 24hr?)
- No absolute lower limit on age is necessary – the older person, as specified above, has full responsibility for the well-being of the younger members of the team.